

## **ROLE: Chartered Accountant (CA)**

### **OVERVIEW**

Chartered Accountants are licensed financial professionals who manage audits, taxation, financial reporting, and advisory services for individuals, businesses, and institutions. In India, the CA designation is awarded by the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) and is one of the most rigorous professional qualifications in finance. CAs work across public accounting firms, corporate finance teams, and independent practice — with senior professionals progressing toward Partner or Equity roles in CA firms.

### **CORE RESPONSIBILITIES**

- Coordinate with Partners for work allocation, progress tracking, and timely completion of deliverables
- Manage client relationships ensuring clear communication, satisfaction, and adherence to agreed timelines
- Provide guidance and training to junior team members for continuous skill development
- Act as a bridge between the senior team and Partner to ensure smooth workflow and quality delivery
- Monitor and ensure achievement of targets and Key Result Areas (KRAs) across assigned mandates
- Drive business development by bringing in and growing quality client portfolios
- Take full ownership of work execution, delivery, and quality across engagements
- Independently manage and expand client relationships over time
- Lead, mentor, and scale teams effectively across practice areas
- Handle strategic responsibilities including transition and takeover of existing firm portfolios

### **CORE PRACTICE AREAS**

A CA in professional practice is expected to be proficient across three primary domains. Audit and assurance involves examining financial records for accuracy and compliance. Taxation covers both direct tax (Income Tax) and indirect tax (GST) — computation, filing, advisory, and representation. Financial advisory includes business valuation, due diligence, restructuring, and strategic counsel to clients on financial decisions.

- Statutory Audit under the Companies Act 2013
- Tax Audit under Section 44AB of the Income Tax Act
- Internal Audit and process review
- Income Tax computation, filing, and representation before tax authorities
- GST compliance, filing, reconciliation, and advisory
- Financial advisory and business consulting
- Due diligence for mergers, acquisitions, and investments
- Company law compliance and secretarial advisory

### **AUDIT AND ASSURANCE**

Audit is the foundation of public accounting. Statutory auditors verify that a company's financial statements give a true and fair view. CAs must understand audit standards (SA — Standards on Auditing issued by ICAI), materiality, sampling techniques, internal control evaluation, and reporting. Tax audits are mandatory for businesses above prescribed turnover thresholds and require specific reporting in Form 3CA/3CB and 3CD.

- Statutory Audit under Companies Act 2013 and applicable SAs
- Tax Audit under Section 44AB — Form 3CA/3CB and 3CD
- Internal Audit for process and control effectiveness
- Bank Audit including concurrent audit and stock audit
- Audit documentation, working papers, and evidence standards
- Reporting of qualifications, emphasis of matter, and key audit matters
- Peer review readiness and quality control standards

### **TAXATION — DIRECT TAX**

Direct taxation in India is governed by the Income Tax Act 1961. CAs handle tax computation for individuals, partnerships, LLPs, and companies; file returns; respond to notices; and represent clients in assessments and appeals. Transfer pricing applies to cross-border transactions between related entities and is a specialized area with high demand.

- Income Tax computation for individuals, firms, LLPs, and companies
- ITR filing across all return forms (ITR-1 through ITR-7)
- TDS compliance — deduction, deposit, and quarterly return filing
- Advance tax computation and planning
- Handling income tax notices, scrutiny assessments, and appeals
- Transfer pricing documentation and compliance for cross-border transactions
- Tax planning and advisory to minimize legal tax liability
- Capital gains computation for property, shares, and mutual funds

## **TAXATION — INDIRECT TAX (GST)**

GST replaced the earlier indirect tax regime in 2017 and is now the primary indirect tax framework in India. CAs handle GST registration, monthly and annual return filing, input tax credit reconciliation, and advisory on GST implications for business transactions. GST audits and departmental proceedings are also within scope.

- GST registration and amendment
- Monthly and quarterly return filing — GSTR-1, GSTR-3B, GSTR-9, GSTR-9C
- Input Tax Credit (ITC) reconciliation and optimization
- GST advisory on supply classification, rate applicability, and exemptions
- Handling GST notices, audits, and departmental proceedings
- E-invoicing and e-way bill compliance
- GST implications for cross-border transactions and imports/exports

## **FINANCIAL REPORTING AND ACCOUNTING**

CAs oversee the preparation and review of financial statements in compliance with applicable standards. Indian Generally Accepted Accounting Principles (Ind AS) align largely with IFRS and apply to listed and large companies. Smaller entities follow older AS standards. CAs must understand the nuances of recognition, measurement, and disclosure under both frameworks.

- Preparation and review of financial statements under Ind AS and AS
- Balance sheet, profit and loss, cash flow, and notes to accounts
- Consolidation of group financial statements
- Revenue recognition, lease accounting, and financial instruments under Ind AS
- Management accounts and MIS reporting for decision support
- Bookkeeping oversight and ledger finalization

## **COMPANY LAW AND REGULATORY COMPLIANCE**

CAs working with corporate clients handle compliance under the Companies Act 2013, including annual filings, board documentation, and SEBI regulations for listed companies. FEMA compliance is required for foreign exchange transactions, foreign investments, and cross-border remittances.

- Annual filings with the Registrar of Companies (ROC) — AOC-4, MGT-7
- Board resolutions and statutory registers maintenance
- SEBI compliance for listed companies
- FEMA compliance for foreign exchange and cross-border transactions
- LLP compliance and annual filings
- Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) proceedings support

## **BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT AND CLIENT MANAGEMENT**

In CA firms, especially at senior and partner-track levels, business development is a core expectation — not a secondary responsibility. CAs are expected to bring in new clients, retain existing ones, and grow the revenue of their practice verticals. Strong client relationships built on trust and consistent delivery quality are the foundation of a successful CA practice.

- Building and expanding client portfolios through referrals and networking
- Client onboarding, engagement letters, and fee negotiation
- Relationship management for long-term client retention
- Cross-selling services across audit, tax, and advisory
- Client communication on regulatory changes and their business impact
- Presenting findings and recommendations to business owners and boards

## **PARTNER TRACK AND LEADERSHIP EXPECTATIONS**

Partner-track roles at CA firms are for professionals who think and act like owners. Partners are responsible for the firm's revenue, client base, quality standards, and team. Moving to equity partnership typically requires the ability to independently bring in clients, lead multiple practice areas, and take ownership of profitability. This is fundamentally entrepreneurial — not just technical.

- Business development and new client acquisition
- End-to-end ownership of client engagements across audit, tax, and advisory
- Team leadership, mentoring, and performance management
- Strategic decision-making on firm growth and practice verticals
- Transition and takeover of existing client portfolios or practice units
- Equity participation and profit-sharing in the firm structure
- Representing the firm in professional and industry circles

## **TOOLS AND TECHNOLOGY**

Modern CA practice uses a mix of accounting software, tax filing utilities, and increasingly, data analytics tools. Proficiency in these is expected at all levels.

- Tally ERP / Tally Prime for accounting and inventory management
- SAP or Oracle Financials for large corporate clients
- GSTN portal and Income Tax portal for direct and indirect tax compliance
- MCA21 portal for company law filings
- Cleartax, Taxmann, or CA software suites for tax computation
- MS Excel for financial modeling, reconciliation, and data analysis
- Audit management software for working paper documentation

## **ICAI REGULATIONS AND PROFESSIONAL COMPLIANCE**

All CA practice in India is governed by the ICAI. Professionals working in CA firms at the junior level are registered as Paid Assistants or Article Assistants as per ICAI norms. Practice rights (the ability to sign audit reports, tax audit reports, and certificates) are held only by licensed Chartered Accountants holding a Certificate of Practice (CoP). Continuing professional education (CPE hours) is mandatory for all CAs.

- Registration as Paid Assistant with the firm as per ICAI regulations
- Certificate of Practice (CoP) required for independent signing authority
- Mandatory CPE hours for license renewal
- Peer review requirements for audit firms above prescribed thresholds
- Code of Ethics and professional conduct standards

## **ELIGIBILITY AND QUALIFICATIONS**

- Qualified Chartered Accountant (CA) — ICAI membership mandatory
- 3–10+ years of post-qualification experience for senior and partner-track roles
- Strong background in Audit, Taxation (Income Tax and GST), and Advisory

- Prior experience in CA firms or professional practice preferred
- Entrepreneurial mindset with ability to drive business and own outcomes

## **PREFERRED CERTIFICATIONS AND ADDITIONAL QUALIFICATIONS**

- DISA (Diploma in Information Systems Audit) from ICAI for IT audit engagements
- Certificate Course in Concurrent Audit from ICAI
- Insolvency Professional (IP) registration under IBBI for IBC work
- CPA (US) or ACCA for international client exposure
- Certified Financial Planner (CFP) for wealth advisory practice
- Masters in Business Administration (MBA Finance) as a complement

## **ENTRY LEVEL EXPECTATIONS**

At the Article Assistant or newly qualified CA level, the expectation is technical execution — accurate tax computations, audit working papers, GST filings, and compliance deliverables. Learning to communicate professionally with clients and understanding the full engagement lifecycle are key development areas.

- Accurate income tax and GST computations and filings
- Audit working paper preparation and documentation
- ROC filing and company law compliance basics
- MS Excel proficiency for reconciliations and schedules
- Communication with clients under supervisor guidance

## **INTERMEDIATE LEVEL EXPECTATIONS**

At 2–5 years post-qualification, CAs are expected to independently manage client files, supervise junior staff, handle notices and assessments, and contribute to business development. They should be able to finalize financial statements and lead audit engagements with minimal partner oversight.

- Independent client management across audit and tax mandates
- Supervision and training of article assistants and junior staff
- Handling income tax and GST notices, assessments, and appeals
- Finalizing financial statements under Ind AS or AS
- Contributing to firm business development and client referrals
- Leading audit engagements from planning to reporting

## **ADVANCED AND PARTNER-TRACK EXPECTATIONS**

At the senior level (5–10+ years), CAs are evaluated on their ability to bring in business, lead practice verticals, and think strategically about firm growth. Partner-track professionals are expected to have their own client relationships, be capable of taking over existing portfolios, and demonstrate readiness for equity participation.

- Building and owning a client portfolio independently
- Leading multiple practice areas (audit, tax, advisory) simultaneously
- Strategic advisory to business owners and boards
- Firm-level decisions on service offerings, pricing, and team structure
- Transition and takeover of client bases or practice units
- Readiness for equity partnership and profit-sharing

## **COMMON ENGAGEMENTS AND PROJECTS**

- Statutory audit of private limited companies and LLPs
- Tax audit and Income Tax filing for high-net-worth individuals and corporates
- GST audit and annual return certification (GSTR-9C)
- Business valuation for M&A transactions or shareholder disputes
- Due diligence for private equity investments
- Restructuring advisory for family-owned businesses

- Transfer pricing documentation for MNC subsidiaries
- Setting up internal audit functions for growing mid-sized companies

## **LEARNING ROADMAP FOR ASPIRING CAs**

Clear the CA Foundation, Intermediate, and Final examinations through ICAI. Complete the mandatory 3-year articleship training with a CA firm — choose a firm with exposure to audit, direct tax, and GST. Use the ICAI's study material and practice previous years' papers. After qualification, join a mid-sized or large CA firm to build technical depth across multiple areas before considering independent practice or partner-track roles. Specialize in one area (international tax, audit, GST litigation) after 3–4 years of broad exposure.

## **RELATED ROLES**

- Tax Consultant
- Financial Controller
- Internal Auditor
- Chief Financial Officer (CFO)
- Insolvency Professional
- Cost and Management Accountant (CMA)
- Company Secretary (CS)
- Investment Banker (with additional finance background)
- Financial Analyst